是在恒常之中寻找变化，在变化之中确认自身。

塔，还在那里。

路，从未消失。

茶，仍在流动，去往世界的每一个角落。

The Great Tea Route Through Time: "New Flames" Brew "New Tea"

Li Tingyi

Preface: A Tower and a Tea Route

At the end of December 2025, Yichang was already deep in winter. On a winter morning, a thin mist lay across the bend of the Yangtze River, and there, in the haze, stood the Tianran Tower—guarding a pool of deep water, facing the river breeze, quietly upright for more than two hundred and thirty years. Tianran Tower is an octagonal, seven-story pavilion-style ancient tower built of brick and stone. Its body rises seven tiers, laid with blue bricks; the eaves curve up slightly, the form simple and dignified, narrowing tier by tier from bottom to top with a clear, upright silhouette. Each tier projects eaves supported by bracket sets; the tower base is octagonal, carved with eight divine guardians bearing the tower, vivid in form. The ground-floor gate faces west toward the river; the lintel is inscribed with the words "Tianran Tower", and couplets on both sides emphasize its imposing presence. The name "Tianran" does not imply that the tower sprang from nature unaided; on the contrary, it embodies a profound philosophy: "to act through human effort so that things appear natural."

The tower was rebuilt during the Qianlong years of the Qing Dynasty with the stated aims of "nurturing the land's pulse, strengthening the cultural peak, taming visiting mountains, and guarding the river mouth", in other words, using human construction to compensate for the deficiencies of natural topography. At that time, the local gentry sought protection from floods and safe passage for boats; people were mainly concerned with the river's rise and fall and the safety of the navigation channel. They could not have foreseen that, over the following century, the tower would be repeatedly written into another history—a history of tea, long journeys, and exchange. In the memory of old Yichang locals, "one can know Yichang by looking at the tower" is a piece of local consensus; among tea entrepreneurs, the Tianran Tower is a beacon on the Great Tea Route—a silent witness to countless consignments of tea that set out from Yichang's hills and traveled the long path to the world.

Water has its way, tea has its road. Going south from Tianran Tower leads to Yidu. Yidu, known as Yidao in ancient times, sits at a crucial point in the middle reaches of the Yangtze

River and has long been a gathering place for northbound and southbound traffic. It is here that Yihong Gongfu Black Tea completed the pivotal leg in its transition from a local product to a commodity in the world market.

Memory of the Old Factory: The Orthodoxy of Yihong Gongfu Black Tea

When you step into the former Yidu Black Tea Factory—a site hailed as the "living industrial heritage of the tea industry" (commonly called the "old factory"), you feel as if time has stood still. Sunlight slants through the glass windows of the high factory halls, and Wang Xianming is inspecting machines that have been silent for more than seventy years: wind selectors, round sieves, dryers, rolling machines... They stand in orderly rows but no longer roar. The iron-and-wood structures bear traces of long wear, like sections of history that have been touched.

As deputy director of the Comprehensive Management Department of Yihong Tea Industry Co., Ltd., Wang Xianming does not come here merely because of his position; most of the time, he walks slowly through the workshops, stopping occasionally to look at a few long-retired pieces of equipment in the corners. Most of those machines were manufactured in the 1960s and 1970s; the paint on their casings has dimmed, and buttons and handrails have been polished bright by repeated handling. He will brush dust off a machine and check whether a bearing needs another dose of lubricant. To him, these machines are no longer mere production tools—they are storytellers, narrating the rhythm of an era and the fate of an industry.

"In the mid-Qing Dynasty period, tea from Sichuan, Yunnan, Guizhou, and the Wuling Mountains of western Hubei all came over the mountains to converge here," Wang Xianming recounts the ancient Yidu section of the Great Tea Route, as if transporting listeners to that distant time: the flora and spirit of the southwestern tea regions were kneaded and rolled into heavy parcels and bricks, then transferred here in the "big-boat to small-boat, small-boat to big-boat" interchange. Speaking of the tea trade along the route during the Qing Dynasty, he says, "Our wooden sailboats loaded with 'Yihong' set off down the Yangtze River, reached Hankou, and then either continued north or turned west."

Through this long and orderly circulation, Yihong Gongfu Black Tea rose to prominence alongside Keemun and Dianhong black tea, forming the "three great Congou black teas". Its distinctive flavor, born of the gorge's mountains and rivers, crossed oceans and earned acclaim in overseas markets. This was genuinely a long road: tea set out from moist mountain forests, passed rivers, grasslands, and frigid zones, and reached into the depths of Eurasia. Along this route, tea ceased to be only a beverage—it became a currency, a gift, a contract,

and a medium of dialogue and understanding between civilizations.

Wang Xianming believes that this road has never been closed. After the founding of the People's Republic of China, it continued in a different form. In 1951, a state-owned tea factory was built on the riverbank. At that time, this was a factory that carried a mission—the black tea it produced was primarily for export. Tea was no longer merely a literati's refreshment; it was a strategic commodity tied to the pulse of the nation.

The river of years flows softly, but changes are evident. In the mid-to-late 1980s, with policy adjustments, tea no longer had to shoulder a single role as an export earner. At the same time, internationally produced broken black teas created fierce price competition, and traditional exported black teas such as Yihong lost advantages in price, transport costs, and global competition. Under the combined influence of policy and market shifts, the policy support that had once favored black tea exports receded, and the Yihong industry's focus moved from dependence on external markets toward developing domestic sales and innovating its own processes.

Consequently, the machines in the old factory began to slow and then fall silent. Wang xianming admits the reason Yihong "did not form a concerted force" in the past: historical disputes over brand ownership and the natural dispersion of the producing area across "two provinces and three localities" led to a situation of "each doing its own thing". In speaking of this, he shows no complaint, only a practical calmness born of reflection; standing again inside the old tea factory, one perceives above all a composed strength.

"We still oil and maintain these machines regularly, and some parts are repaired or replaced," Wang Xianming stands beside an old rolling machine and explains. In fact, he is also a provincial-level representative inheritor, apprenticed to an older generation of tea masters. As a member of the unit charged with protecting this heritage, he prefers to call the site a "living industrial heritage of the tea industry". He has pushed for tidying up the factory grounds, restoring equipment, and creating display spaces to preserve Yihong's history clearly. "Protecting it is not to turn it into a cold museum exhibit," he says, "but to keep it as the 'matrix' of Yihong tea, a vessel of memory that continues to breathe." This devotion to preserving orthodoxy is both a tribute to past glory and a guarding of the craft's roots.

At four in the afternoon, slanting sunlight gilds the old machines with warm edges. Wang Xianming finishes his inspection for the day and locks the workshop door. The key turns with a crisp sound that echoes far across the empty hall. He lingers outside for a moment, his gaze sweeping the mottled walls as though listening to the building's silent speech. Then he turns and walks away, his silhouette melting into the light beyond the doorway. It is an ordinary day: nothing epoch-making occurs, only another day in which tradition is guarded and, quietly, a path to the future is being laid.

"New Flames" Brew "New Tea": From Process Innovation to Brand Journeys

However, if preservation alone is all there is, the aroma of tea would be confined to old papers and the old factory. Genuine inheritance must include courageous innovation. Baota Bay's scenery has already changed—where tea boats once crowded the wharves, modern urban structures now rewrite the landscape—but the tea route has never been severed. It has quietly extended from the bustling docks into quiet laboratories and intelligent production workshops, and onto strategic blueprints for global brands.

In the R&D room of Yichang Tea Group (referred to as Yicha Group), a flavor revolution is underway. Zhou Bin, assistant general manager of the brand marketing department, brews a cup of newly processed Yihong Gongfu Black Tea; the tea infusion is bright red. He does not rush to let people taste it; first, he picks up a traditional export sample beside it—a weighty, tight, black granular tea. "In the past, our black teas were mainly for export," Zhou explains. "Teas like this, heavily cut and fully fermented, conform to traditional European tastes. But many domestic consumers find the flavor too strong and the appearance not 'attractive' enough."

Change arises from such contrasts. Yicha Group has begun to re-evaluate the possibilities of Yihong. They combine the masters' experience with modern tea-processing technology. Zhou explains, "We borrowed techniques from green tea production, adjusted the degree of fermentation, and produced a new type of Yihong more in line with domestic aesthetic and taste preferences." Without altering the varietal essence, they adjusted processing logic and adopted green-tea ideas to control fermentation so that the tea retains black tea characteristics while presenting a clearer appearance and a softer palate. Thus, a new type of Yihong was born. Zhou points to the unfurling leaves in the glass cup: slender strands, visible golden tips. Testing shows higher levels of tea polyphenols and theaflavin monomers and a reasonable proportion of soluble sugars, producing a sweeter, rounded taste and a finer mouthfeel. This change is not mere pandering; it is a substantive response to contemporary drinking habits.

Innovation is not limited to a single cup. Inside the modern workshop of Hubei Xiaoshi Tea co., Ltd., Yicha Group, another kind of change is taking place.

Behind the glass walls, a fully automated production line—lauded as a "man-less factory"—runs quietly and efficiently. This is one of the largest commercial tea-processing facilities in Hubei Province, housing several domestically and internationally sourced intelligent production lines with an annual design processing capacity of up to 10000 tons. From raw material handling to finished packaging, every step is standardized: the leaf enters on conveyors into modules for cleaning, fixation, rolling, drying, and other procedures; the automation system precisely controls temperature, humidity, fermentation time, and

conveyor speed according to preset programs, making the processing chain largely independent of traditional manual judgment. This intelligent workflow not only raises operational efficiency but also greatly reduces human-caused variability in taste and quality. At the end of the workshop, an automated packing machine fills tea into compact modern boxes, minimalist in design and stamped with a striking brand name "Yivana".

"This is our own overseas brand," the general manager, Xiang Qinghua, says with pride. It is a new overseas-export attempt under the Yicha system and a way for Yichang tea to re-enter the global market. Yicha Group's innovators are leveraging Anqi Group's international network to push this "new tea" abroad.

"Yivana" sounds at once ancient and modern: "Yi" for Yichang, "Vana" meaning forest in Sanskrit—simply put, "good tea from Yichang". Its founding is rooted in the grander backdrop of Yicha Group's formation. Historically, Yichang tea often disappeared as bulk raw material in long supply chains where value and identity were stripped away. For a long time, Yichang tea, despite its quality, suffered from "a category without a strong brand"—companies operating individually, unable to form synergy. Yivana's birth carries the mission of integrating Yichang's advantageous tea resources and representing the producing region's collective image to directly knock on the international market door. Its appearance marks a key step in Yichang tea's transition from scattered raw-material suppliers to unified brand operators. In early 2024, Yivana reached its first milestone: the first shipment of 3.5 tons of small-pack tea was dispatched to African markets. That was not merely an order but a signal: relying on the integrated industrial chain of the Yicha Group and Anqi Group's global network, Yichang tea is re-entering the global supply chain under its own brand. By 2025, products bearing the Yivana label were steadily supplied to the Middle East, Africa, and other regions, reaching ordinary households across oceans.

"We have achieved a shift from 'raw-material export' to 'brand export'," Xiang Qinghua says. Since 2022, the Yivana series has been sold to more than 30 countries and regions. Yichang's product line has diversified beyond Yihong to include high-quality green teas. "Zhenmei" is an exemplary Yichang green tea: slender as an eyebrow, fresh and mellow in taste; it, together with Yihong Gongfu Black Tea, composes the flavor matrix by which Yichang tea projects itself onto the world stage. Especially in places such as Kenya and Morocco, Yivana meets a local demand for strong-flavored green teas; Zhenmei, produced to a very high standard, is becoming an indispensable daily beverage.

"In the past, tea was more often treated as an agricultural product," he says, "but now it must also be an industrial product and a food product. These three aspects determine how far we can go." Tea is now sent out as a "Yichang calling card"; this is no longer 19th-century barter trade, but rather the contemporary embedding of the Great Tea Route into the global supply chain. The internationalization of brands is always accompanied by the challenge of

how the "Yichang flavor" will be recognized and accepted globally. Today, this name, grown on the banks of the Yangtze River, is not only a trademark but a mobile coordinate that lets "Yichang" find its place on the world tea map in a way that is both palatable and memorable.

Tea Returning to Everyday Life: Hills, Seasons, and People's Lives

Innovation is not only product and channel reform; it is also bringing tea back into daily life, letting history illuminate the present—the tea growing on the hills is not simply cargo to be shipped away but the background color of local people's lives.

Every late spring into early summer, when the valley mists have not yet dispersed, Yichang's tea mountains begin to bustle. On the eastern foothills of the Wuling Mountains, in Wufeng Tujia Autonomous County—undisputedly the homeland of Yihong tea and an important source area for the Great Tea Route—over 200000 mu of tea gardens awaken from the morning fog. This land, with a tea culture history spanning over 2000 years, is today acclaimed as "the First Tea Town in the Chu Region". The county achieved an output of 30000 tons of finished tea, and the annual industrial value of the tea industry exceeded 1.4 billion yuan.

Meanwhile, on the north bank of the Yangtze River's Three Gorges, in Dengcun Township of Yiling District, Yichang City—a town hailed as a "Hometown of China's Famous Teas" and a "World Tea Tourism Town", another scene unfolds. The first-picked tender buds are gently pinched off by tea farmers' fingertips; they are not only raw materials for top-quality teas but also carry the mission of transforming from traditional cultivation to a deep integration of "tea, culture, and tourism".

"We plan to further develop a typical 'three-tea' cultural-tourism integration route of 'tea production-tea consumption-tea leisure', so that visitors can truly experience the charm of tea culture," says Shang Qinghua. The liveliest days are the opening-festival days of the tea gardens in Wufeng, Dengcun, and the like. As early spring arrives and everything revives, the buds are still drowsy; tea farmers climb the winding mountain paths to assemble between hillsides and peaks. At the garden-opening festival, with drums sounding softly, people inhale the season's mountain freshness, and then call to the mountains with the most primordial voice: "The tea buds have sprouted!"—the long shout of the "shan-calling" first pierces the valley silence, and then tea songs intertwine with the melodious Tujia Nanqu (a traditional southern tune of the Tujia ethnic group), passing generations' labor and hopes on to each new leaf.

The power of the "shan-calling" lies not only in its sound but in the emotion and aspiration behind it. For people who make their living from tea, it is a declaration of spring to heaven and

earth, a prayer for the year's labor and hopes; it is a devout response to the land's gifts and a resonance that places humans within nature's rhythms—encompassing both anticipation of harvest and silent respect for nature.

Today, the garden-opening festival's meaning has expanded from traditional "sacrificial rites praying for abundance" into a vehicle for "boosting rural income through tea and promoting tourism through culture", allowing a tea leaf to embody a locality's most ardent hopes for rural revitalization across the board.

Between such everydayness and ceremony, Yichang's tea-tourism routes are quietly taking shape. They are not contrived like urban sightseeing lines, but instead link together a complete chain: tea picking on the hills, hands-on workshops in tea processing, study visits to the Xiaoshi Tea Museum, and tea-tasting sessions. Visitors can pick tea alongside farmers, learn temperature control and firing techniques in processing sheds, and touch historical artifacts in the tea museum to feel the history of the Great Tea Route. "This experience has no barrier; it returns tea from being merely a commodity to the way people first recognized it—as a daily practice and a shared communal memory," Shang Qinghua says. In these overlapping experiences, tea becomes internalized into people's daily lives and re-integrated into people's experience and language.

Conclusion: The Tower Stands by the River, Tea Follows Its Way

The honey-fruit sweetness in the amber-gold infusion of the new type of Yihong, the precisely running automated lines in the workshop, the Yivana small-pack teas shipped across oceans, and even the "shan-calling" ritual that wakes spring on tea slopes and the walkable, experiential tea-tour trails—all of these converge into today's visible "new flame". This "new flame" clarifies tea's presence in more people's lives and turns the once-silent terms "the Great Tea Route" and "long journey" into something tangible, touchable, and drinkable in the present. The old "big-boat to small-boat" exchanges are a testament to caravans and sailboats crossing thousands of mountains and rivers to carry tea to the world; today's "new flame" brewing "new tea" is more a conversation of civilizations—forging cross-linguistic trust through standards, telling unique terroir stories through branding, and converting culture into immersive, firsthand life experiences through tea-tourism integration. It illuminates the past and penetrates the present.

The setting sun gilds Tianran Tower; the river flows silently east as ever; reflected on the water are no longer the sails of wooden boats but the traffic on cross-river bridges and the neon lights of distant high-rises. Everything seems to change—the river's speed, boat designs, the look of tea, and its travel routes. Yet some things remain unchanged: the river

still longs for broader horizons, and the people of this land still willingly take the modest, rustic fragrance of the hills and woods, kneading and roasting it with all their heart, then doing their utmost to send it afar.

"New flame" is not a denial of old craft; "new tea" is not a betrayal of tradition. The novelty lies in seeking change within constancy, and in affirming identity amid change.

The tower still stands.

The road has never vanished.

Tea still flows, bound for every corner of the world.